

standard_onboarding_curriculum

Onboarding Curriculum Standard

Purpose

Defines the minimum curriculum that any Junior Backend Developer onboarding program must cover before a new hire is considered ready for unsupervised feature work. This standard exists because informal, ad hoc onboarding — where a new hire's ramp-up depends heavily on which team they join and how much time their manager happens to have available in their first weeks — has historically produced highly inconsistent time-to-productivity across teams within the organization.

Scope

Applies to all Junior Backend Developer onboarding tracks, regardless of the specific team or product a new hire joins. Teams may add additional, team-specific onboarding content beyond what is specified here, but may not omit any of the required components below.

Required Curriculum Components

Component 1: Environment Setup

New hires must be able to independently clone, build, and run the primary service locally, including its database dependencies, within their first three working days. This is deliberately treated as a hard requirement rather than a soft goal, because an inability to run the codebase locally blocks nearly every other onboarding activity that follows.

If a new hire has not achieved a working local environment by the end of day three, this must be escalated to the onboarding buddy and manager as a blocker requiring dedicated pairing time, rather than allowed to continue silently slipping into later weeks.

Component 2: Codebase Orientation

New hires must complete a guided walkthrough of the primary service's architecture, including its layering conventions (for example, which directories correspond to domain, application, and infrastructure concerns if the codebase follows a clean architecture style), and where to find existing tests for a given piece of functionality.

This walkthrough should be conducted by a team member, not merely handed to the new hire as a written document to read independently, since questions that arise naturally during a live walkthrough are often more valuable than the walkthrough content itself.

Component 3: Version Control Practices

New hires must demonstrate the ability to create a properly named branch, make a scoped, atomic commit with a clear message, and open a pull request following the team's conventions, including a complete description covering what changed, why, and how it was tested.

Component 4: First Contribution

New hires must submit at least one reviewed and merged pull request within their first two weeks, scoped to a well-defined, genuinely low-risk task (such as a documentation fix, a small test addition, or a minor, well-isolated bug fix) — deliberately chosen to build confidence and familiarity with the team’s actual review and merge process on a real, low-stakes change, rather than a purely synthetic practice exercise disconnected from the real codebase.

Component 5: Security Basics

New hires must complete the organization’s security awareness training (covering, at minimum, secrets handling, input validation, and common vulnerability classes) before receiving production access credentials of any kind, including read-only access to production data.

Sign-Off Requirements

A new hire is considered onboarded when their manager confirms all five components are complete and documents this explicitly in the onboarding tracker, including the date each component was completed and who verified it. Partial completion (for example, four of five components) should not be marked as “onboarded” even informally, since production access decisions depend on this sign-off being accurate and complete.

Escalation Path

If a new hire has not completed onboarding within four weeks of their start date, this is escalated automatically to the Engineering Enablement Team for review, regardless of the reason for the delay — this is intended as a support mechanism to identify and address blockers early, not as a punitive measure directed at the new hire.

Standard Owner

Engineering Enablement Team, responsible for reviewing and updating this standard at least annually, or sooner if a pattern of onboarding gaps is identified across multiple teams.